

came to power in Uttar Pradesh after the last Assembly elections in 2007 by winning 206 of the state's 403 seats, it had been leading in 55 of the state's 80 parliamentary constituencies.

The Left's plan of getting a foothold in Uttar Pradesh by contesting in four constituencies has also been struck down by Mayawati with a barter proposal. While the CPI(M) state committee had expressed its plans to contest from Allahabad and Kanpur, the CPI had been eyeing the Ghosi and Varanasi seats. The BSP silenced them by asking for a seat in Kerala where the party has a small presence with the backing of Kerala Pulayar Maha

Jat allies of the front, Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) leader Om Prakash Chautala and RLD chief Ajit Singh, scorn the idea of Mayawati as prime minister. The TRS, INLD and AGP are being wooed by the BJP while both the Congress and the BJP are trying desperately to bring the RLD into their folds.

In Tamil Nadu, J. Jayalalithaa is reciprocating to the UNPA overtures. Telugu Desam Party (TDP) leader N. Chandrababu Naidu and Gowda have also been in touch with the AIADMK leader. The CPI(M) is on its way of snapping ties with the DMK in the state. "The Left party has made it clear to the DMK that it should decide whether it

the Third Front floating, may opt for a tie-up with Jayalalithaa.

For the Left, swapping the DMK for the AIADMK is not an easy task. It was due to M. Karunanidhi's support that CPI's D. Raja and CPI(M)'s T.K. Rangarajan got an entry into the Rajya Sabha. The DMK leaders privately argue that these leaders should step down if the Left pulls out of the DMK-led alliance in the state. Many parties in the Third Front—AGP, TDP, BSP and JD(S)—have shared power with the BJP and have failed to attain the earlier qualifying mark set by Karat: "impeccable secular credentials". With Jayalalithaa's entry, the Third Front will have one more

TEETHING TROUBLES

■ If Mayawati becomes the president of the alliance, PM aspirant Deve Gowda may play hooky.

■ Mayawati's demand for a seat in Kerala in lieu of four seats in Uttar Pradesh has put the Left in a dilemma.

■ JD(S) has already had talks with the Congress about reviving their previous alliance.

■ Left parties are divided on Chiranjeevi's new party. CPI wants him, big brother CPI(M) doesn't.

■ A possible Jayalalithaa entry into the Third Front would mean the alliance will have one more party "tainted" by the BJP.



SOUTHERN DISCOMFORT: Chiranjeevi

H K RAJASHEKAR

Sabha, a Dalit outfit, set up by social reformist Ayyankali. The CPI(M) does not want further acceleration of caste-based mobilisation by a dedicated caste party in its traditional stronghold. The party had held a Dalit convention at Kochi about a week back—a rare event in communist calendar—but was aptly ridiculed by the BSP as a "new-found love" for the Dalits.

Karat's immediate concern is to settle the liquidity worries of the Third Front. H.D. Kumaraswamy, Gowda's son and former Karnataka chief minister, has already held discussions with Congress's Ahmed Patel about reviving their previously doomed tie-up in Karnataka. The two

wants to join hands with the Congress or with the CPI(M). Historically, the CPI(M) has never sided with the communal BJP or the Congress, and would make all efforts to float a Third Front in Tamil Nadu," said N. Varadarajan, CPI(M) state secretary.

The party's state unit is reportedly against any tie-up with Jayalalithaa even as it does not want to join its rival the DMK. "People have been waiting for long to teach a lesson to the BJP-led NDA for its four-and-a-half years of misrule as well as to Jayalalithaa for her tyrannical rule in the state for three years," the CPI(M) had said in a statement when the previous AIADMK government had been voted out of power. Karat, under pressure to keep

party which has supped with the BJP.

The CPI's hush-hush talks with Chiranjeevi's newly-floated Praja Rajyam have also left the Third front ally TDP red-faced. While the CPI(M) is in favour of an alliance with the TDP, CPI's state unit considers the party an untouchable. Karat is now hoping that CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan will succeed in changing the powerful state unit's mind. The CPI(M) insists that Mayawati, after their meeting on August 24, has agreed to make concessions on seat sharing and the alliance would soon convene a meeting for planning further campaigns. Going by the turf war within the alliance, perhaps only an astrologer can say how united those campaigns will be. ■